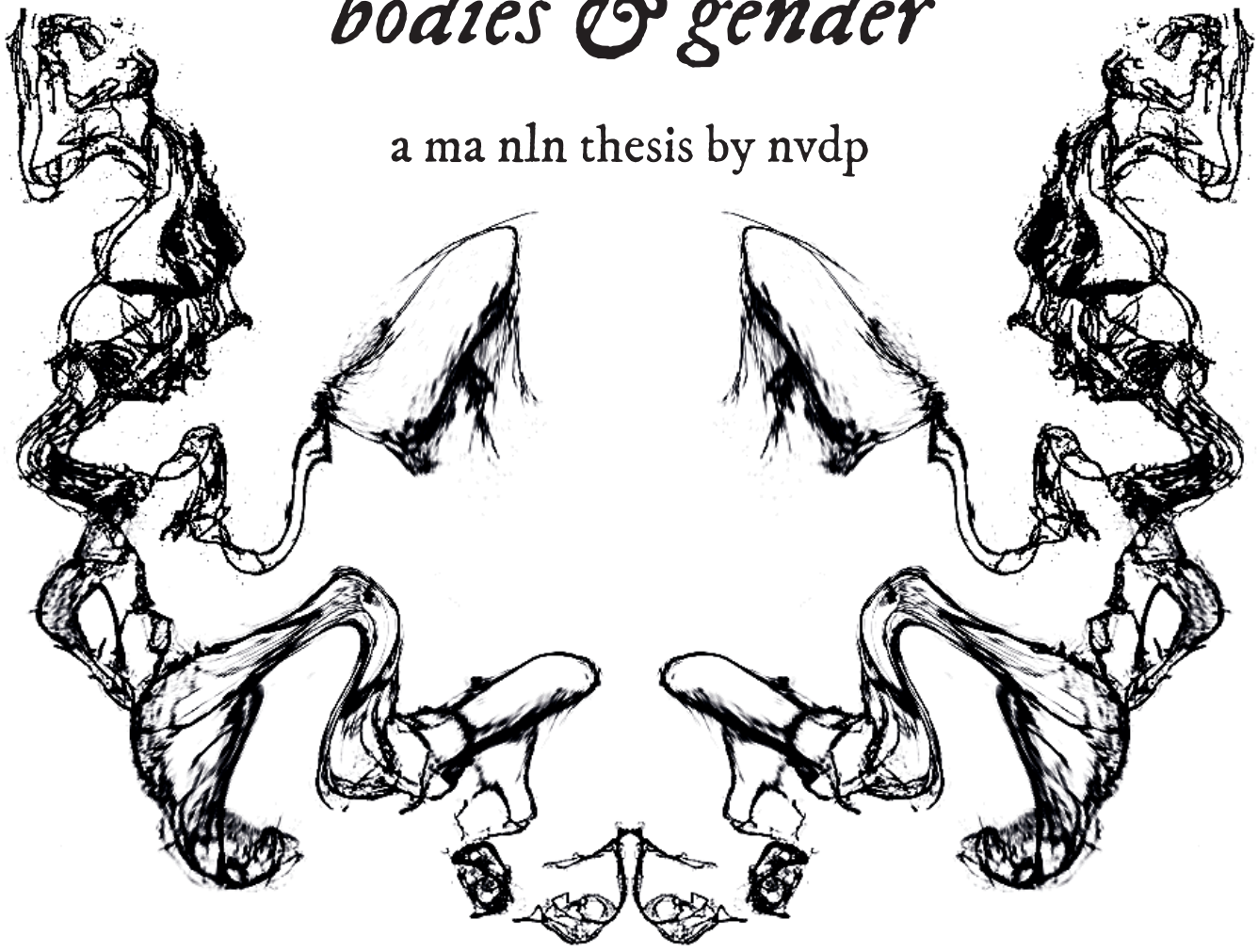
Becoming Monstrous: Queering horror to investigate bodies & gender

a ma nln thesis by nvdp



Becoming Monstrous: Queering Horror to investigate bodies & gender.

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General Disclaimer:

Before getting into the meat of it, we* would like to add a little disclaimer: NVDP is a non-binary entity, using they/them pronouns. Within this thesis we position ourselves as vulnerable and volatile, fractured even. NVDP is a designer, 3D artist and amateur storyteller, we* do not claim to be an academic expert on queer, gender or horror**, nor do we have any inflated sense of self-importance, we do not wish to follow a solutionist philosophy that is commonly prevalent in design mentalities. We are not saving the world, we merely try to question it, and through a lens of queerness, see how others readings and perceptions of our world are possible.

*When the term 'we' is used within this thesis, 'we' refers to NVDP, the writer of the thesis. We do this because, we believe that no person, is a singular, one dimensional being, we are all complex, multi-faceted, interconnected beings, so writing from an 'I' perspective does not make sense to us. This is a freedom given to us, in writing only.

**When the term horror is used within this thesis, we refer to it within the context of fiction. We investigate the narratives and motives within these fictional bodies of work. We use literary and cinematic examples of horror as a lens to talk about gender and queerness.

Contextualization on the writing within the thesis:

We are writing from a queer, gender non-conforming perspective. To attempt to and write about that which is fluid, shape shifting and ever changing, is a challenging task. To solidify it, in words and writing, is almost defeating the purpose of being fluid. To give a definition of a concept is to lose meaning of possible interpetations. It is more akin to chasing a shadow or hunting a ghost. By filling in the gaps the flow becomes restrained. And although we will do the ultimate best to be as coherent as possible within this narration. We simply do not have the power, nor do we wish to have the power, to fully articulate that which queer communities categorizes as 'non-binary'. Because the 'non' part, will always be overruled by the binary part. Much like with non-linearity, as Tyson Yunkaporta states in 'Sand Talks': "Explaining Aboriginal notions of time is an exercise in futility as you can only describe it as 'non-linear' in English, which immediately slams a big line right across your synapses. You don't register the 'non'—only the 'linear': that is the way you process that word, the shape it takes in your mind. Worst of all, it is only describing the concept by saying what it is not, rather than what it is" (Yunkaporta, 28). The same argument extends to non-binary seeing as both non-binary and non-linearity speak about a level of complexity, they also both challenge what is the norm, as in linear time and binary thinking. We acknowledge the limitations of language in describing these fluid concepts and we invite you to see gaps not as missing pieces, but as spaces to mutate, unfold and follow ones stream of consciousness, keep in mind:

"All readings are also mis-readings, re-readings, partial readings, imposed readings, and imagined readings of a text that is originally and finally never simply there. Just as the world is originally fallen apart, the text is always already enmeshed in contending practices and hopes." (Haraway, "Simians, Cyborgs, and Women" 124)

"Fixation is the way to death. Fluidity is the way to life."
—Miyamoto Musashi (宮本武蔵)

There are two ways to view the body.
Resurrection and crucifixion.
Everything that falls between is ritual.
— Chris Abani, Sanctificum

I am a collection of dismantled almosts.
— Anne Sexton, Anne Sexton: A Self-Portrait in Letters

Introduction

{As a child, we remember that we'd tell our mother: "I don't fit inside of me", mother would always answer: "I don't know what that means". Every time, those words stung. What it meant is that we were not understood, we lived a life, separated from our body and this separation was extended towards the people around. We felt no connection to boyhood or manhood, no connection to brother, to father, no connection to ourself. So mother was our last hope, as unfair as that was towards her, to find some understanding. But even that turned out to be futile. You see, walking passed a mirror, felt like shattering it. Every interaction, deemed casual for most, needed a period of recovery for us. We had to lick our mental wounds clean. But it was not just a knee-jerk reaction, not just a reaction of shock or a mental pain, it was physical as well, horrendously palpable, it reached so deep, we felt it, crawling underneath our skin, scratching behind our eyes: the colossal weight, our soul was perpetually crushed. The disconnect was too large to bare. It was this massive weight of perception that pushed and pushed, keeping us trapped in our flesh prison, revealing to us, we are other...and the world seemed to be filled with hostility towards all that is other, the world seemed to be filled with torches and pitch forks.}

This thesis must be seen as an act of reclaiming terminology like 'monster', 'freak', 'creature', 'unnatural', for the gender-queer. We do not reclaim them to function as terms of othering, but as terms of liberation. This is a piece of writing where fictions, dreams and fantasies intertwine with realities in order to form a narrative that contemplates what alternative views can be offered to our current patriarchal heteronormative capitalist societal views on bodies, gender and identity. More specifically we will use the body as a vehicle to talk about binarism, gender, and a world beyond it. In this case, the body forms an abstract architecture for world building, in Glitch Feminism the body is approached as a world-building word, something that gives shape to abstract ideas. Russell explains that bodies are a source of potential, all beginning in abstraction, only to be limited by gender constructions and performance of gender. Russell argues that bodies must return to abstraction, to de-materialize and transcend these limitations. (Russell 41) Within this thesis we wish to stress this idea, we want to glitch, to flow, to haunt, to float, we want to be abstract, we don't want to be assimilated by heteronormativity, we salivate over the idea of being illegible to heteronormativity without being harmed by it, we crave for an existence on our own terms.

Through the body, an ontological anchor, we can speak about how gender is forced upon us, how we start to perform our gender roles, how we are pulled from abstraction, forced to materialize. How can we unlearn this? How can we create avenues for their deconstruction and transcendence, paving the way for the emergence of alternative realities? Our discourse will be informed by a myriad of theoretical frameworks. Legacy Russell (Glitch Feminism), Judith Butler (gender performativity), Susan Stryker (transgender as monstrosity), Deleuze (Becoming, Bodies Without Organs) and Donna Haraway (Cyborg/Cyber Feminism) will form the central ones. This in order to substantiate our claims and facilitate an in-depth exploration of the inscription of societal expectations how the body is inscribed with functions and expectations (reproductive labor, physical appearance, societal roles) and how we can move towards a reading of being that breaks away from these inscriptive mechanisms. Within the thesis the body will form an example, for us, to explore ways of world building: a way to think about narratives and language: through the body we will move into the world of horror fiction where we investigate how bodies within horror are illegible, abstract, sewn together, unnatural spawns and how they can be linked to issues of gender and queer identities. We will form a queer lens by performing queer readings, re-readings and purposeful mis-readings of some of these fictional horror stories to unarchive ways to read a body that is not prioritizing heteronormativity and patriarchal thinking. Before we dissect that further, we must first deal with the material base: the body —our very corporeality— and how gender, forced upon it, causes to invariably constrain and encompass our being.

A sentencing loop of inscribed flesh: the gendered body

When humans are born, they are sentenced to life. Humans are sentenced to flesh, solidified into a body that is no longer surrounded and nurtured by the softness, pliability and liquidity of the womb. This body is then subjected to a myriad of sociocultural constructs, including but not limited to those pertaining to race, gender, and class. The body becomes a tool for classification. It is flattened: becoming a one-dimensional, singular object. The body is forced to become recognizable: it must be legible. In this flattening process, one is stripped of agency over how this body is interpreted. Your body is hyper-visible, you are violently perceived, without consent. The body becomes a model to give form to abstract ideas and to inscribe it with social, political and cultural discourse which impacts the way bodies are read (Russell 15). Gender is an integral part in how bodies are read and what is being inscribed into those bodies. To put if differently, gender determines what kind of model your body becomes, an archetypal role that one's body assumes through classification as male or female and the functions, conditions and fixity that is attached to these classifications with gender performance as its score (Russell 15).

The body performs gender, it is not something that is inherent, or natural, it is a performative act. This notion was established by Judith Butler in the late eighties with their essay 'Performative Acts and Gender Constitution: An Essay in Phenomenology and Feminist Theory'. Throughout their career, Butler argues that Gender is a behavior that is performed, through repetition and ritualization, which causes certain behaviors to become recognizable as belonging to a specific gender category, contributing to the construction and maintenance of gender norms. This process of repetition is crucial in understanding how gender identities are stabilized and reproduced within society. In essence, gender is a continuous process of enactment and reiteration. Individuals "do" gender through their actions, expressions, and behaviors. But seeing as Gender is a behavior, performed as if it were a ritual, we can change it, unlearn it, detach from it. This is by no means an easy task, seeing as societal norms are also dynamic and change over time, their adaptive nature makes it difficult to completely rid ourselves of them. Furthermore, these performative acts are often unconscious, so even recognizing how, when, where and why we are performing them is a challenge. However, it is necessary to see that the production of gender identity is not done freely, it is through systemic violence, the violence of gender, that we are forced to engage with it. It becomes a method of control and reproduction as the performance becomes a lie, repeated to the extent that it becomes natural and inescapable (Storm, Flores 6). Because gender goes further than a mere passive obedience, it is coercion, a form of exploitation, gender is disciplining you, to the point it becomes an imposed and enforced identity, reshaping the entire persona in the process (Federici 46). Considering these dynamics, of the eternal cycle of violent engagement and disciplining, gendered bodies are falsely rendered as the hegemonic normative. This binary way of perceiving bodies creates modalities of otherness, anything outside of it becomes monstrous. It becomes important, as a means of survival, as a means of reclamation and as a means of recalibration to explore strategies that liberate us from these dynamics forced upon us, or at least find ways to liberate ourselves to some extent within these dynamics.

A perpetual in-between: becoming-imperceptible

It is necessary to devise means to subvert the constructs of gender and disengage from the performative acts that sustain its normative authority. For this, we can turn towards Deleuze and Guattari and their conceptualization of "becoming-imperceptible". Becoming-imperceptible is part of their larger philosophical idea of "becoming" which is basically a rejection of fixed identity and instead propose that entities are always in the process of becoming something else. This becoming is not a linear progression but involves dynamic transformations and connections. The "imperceptible" aspect of becoming-imperceptible highlights the subtle and elusive nature of these processes of becoming. The transformations are not easily perceived or categorized. Deleuze and Guattari use the metaphor of the "rhizome" to illustrate the concept of becoming-imperceptible. The rhizome is a horizontal, non-hierarchical structure of interconnected multiplicities that resists fixed organization. It stands in contrast to the hierarchical tree structure that represents traditional modes of thinking. Becoming-imperceptible encourages a more fluid and open understanding of identity: entities are not confined to fixed forms, they are assemblages. These assemblages are multiplicities, becomings, segments, vibrations, which together forms the abstract machine (Deleuze and Guattari 252). Within these various assemblages, there exists more or less an infinity of interconnected relations between the inanimate and animate, the artificial and the organic.

Deleuze and Guattari avoid defining the body based on organs, forms, functions or design, as they iterate on the ideas of Spinoza, they proclaim "We know nothing about a body until we know what it can do (257)" What a body can do, is based on how bodies form relations with their affects, with other bodies, with other's bodies affects, in a rhizomatic way of relationality. It is based on all the ways the body is becoming, and what is important to note about the process of becoming is that: "all becoming is a becoming-minoritarian" (291) by which they mean, that there is no becoming-man, because man is the majority when it comes to a state of domination. They argue that becoming, any form of becoming, moves through a becoming-woman. So whether it is becoming-animal, becoming-imperceptible, all forms of go through the process of becoming-woman. Becoming-as-transition in a process of deterritorialization. Becoming is neither past nor future, neither beginning nor end, neither origin nor absence of origin, "A becoming is always in the middle" (293). Gender identity is not a fixed endpoint but a dynamic journey, Deleuze and Guattari

hint at this notion as well stating: “We know that many beings pass between a man and a woman” “they cannot be understood in terms of production, only in terms of becoming” (242). The production of gender, the performance of it, the coercion into being a gendered body is not the way of knowing the body, not the correct reading. Only through a process of becoming: these non-linear dynamics of movements and forces acting and being acted upon, we are able to read the body, not as a singular entity, not as a synonym for person, not as an antagonism to mind, but as a dynamic.

Horrors to Come: What are we investigating?

We will be touching upon many becomings: becoming-cyborg, becoming-illegible, becoming-monster. By seeing points of connection between the bodies of work by Susan Stryker, Gilles Deleuze, Donna Haraway, Legacy Russell, Laura Westengard and others, reading into the genre of horror through these lenses while waving our personal views and experiences into all of it, we propose a postmodern, posthuman, queer narrative that moves away from essentialism and into assemblaging.

In our first chapter we will explore the queerness of horror, by using the genre of body horror as a lens to talk about body and gender. We outline in what ways do body horror films, through their depictions of loss of control over the body and extreme bodily reconfigurations, parallel the experiences of individuals navigating non-binary identities, proposing that the genre can be read as a metaphorical expression of gender non-conforming and trans experiences. We will also re-introduce Deleuze and Guattari as we explore body horror through their philosophical concept of “Body-Without-Organs”. Through a more in-depth analysis of specific films like ‘Tetsuo: The Iron Man’, and ‘Titane’ we question what thematic elements and narrative choices in these films contribute to the broader exploration of gender identity, dysphoria, technology, and the (post-)human experience? And by connecting them to ‘A Cyborg Manifesto’ by Donna Haraway, we argue that these two films embody and visualize Haraway’s concept of the cyborg.

In our second chapter we will explore the horror of queerness, in a theoretical and literary sense, playing on this idea of the gender non-conforming as monstrosity. The chapter will draw on arguments from Susan Stryker, Melody Hope Cooper and Ana Cristina Santos, and the historical association of transgender identity with the monstrous. We propose to view horror as a transformative process characterized by positive reclamation, as we build on Stryker’s perspective of embracing the monstrous. Monstrosity is analyzed as a concept with historical roots, serving as messengers of cultural insights and within this chapter we propose that the gender-queer figure can act as a contemporary extension of the historical role of monster, acting as a messenger of redefining societal norms towards a more inclusive and fluid understanding: a becoming-monster of sorts.

“Welts, scars, cuts, tattoos, perforations, incisions, inlays, function quite literally to increase the surface space of the body, creating out of what may have been formless flesh a series of zones, locations, ridges, hollows, contours : places of special significance and libidinal intensity.”
— Elizabeth Grosz, Volatile Bodies

“Who has not asked himself at some time or other: am I a monster or is this what it means to be a person?”
— Clarice Lispector, The Hour of the Star

“The aim is to balance the terror of being alive with the wonder of being alive.”
— Carlos Castaneda

Chapter 1: “Oh, horrid body, what new sights can you show us.”

{Sometimes, it is the opposite, we do not feel crushed by weight, we feel more like being ripped apart. Every second of every day. Like the Oroborus, consuming itself, for all of eternity. We feel like we are constantly spread thin, stretched out, so many tensions, always so many tensions, we wish to burst into tears, or just burst apart, in a gooey red mess of blood and organs. Would it paint a picture? Scrape our parts off of the walls of society, we would put the ‘hot’ in hot mess haha. Truly, it feels like quartered, all the fucking time, do you know that scene in the first ‘Hellraiser’ movie? Where Uncle Frank was torn apart by meat hooks? Kind of like that…every second of every day. Clive Barker and David Cronenberg are the best thing to happen to modern cinema in our opinion, after David Lynch, that is. Yes, the work of Barker and Cronenberg is maybe disgusting, but at least they are creative with bodies. Aren’t you fucking bored of yours? We sure as hell are of ours. To us horror, as in the depiction found in literary and cinematic horror, is actually appealing, these creature designs, so free of a form dictated by function, so free of inscriptions, free to be illegible. No, to us the current state of reality is real hell: being perceived as the shape I currently come by, that is real horror. So unimaginative...We can never float, overflow, contort, I just want to be so many…}

In this first chapter we will further dissect and analyze the body and figure out new reconfigurations or understandings of the body. We will explore transformations and metamorphosis of the body through the concept of the cyborg as introduced by Haraway and mentioned earlier in this thesis, as well as explore transformations in

more visceral and grotesque ways by investigating the cinematic genre of 'body horror' and argue that this specific sub-genre of horror can be read as a metaphor for gender non-conforming and trans experiences. There is also an inherent queerness, automatically woven into body horror, as it is an offspring of Gothic fictions. In 'Queer Horror' by Laura Westengard they build on arguments made by George Haggerty in 'Queer Gothic' and Max Finscher in 'Queering Gothic in the Romantic Age: The Penetrating Eye' to illustrate that Gothic fiction functioned as a space where unauthorized genders and sexualities that never followed a straight course could be explored (Westengard 7) and states that: 'Nonnormative genders and sexualities circulate throughout the Gothic' (7). Body horror is spawned from Gothic, with Mary Shelley's Frankenstein being an early example of the body horror sub-genre, and both body horror and Gothic share similarities in the way they deal with the uncanny, where the familiar becomes strange or unsettling. Both genres also deal with the violation of boundaries, the ruination of the human body, the fear of the unknown and the psychological horrors around the idea of self. Because this connected lineage and heritage, we feel that all these argumentation about Gothic, can be extended to the genre of body horror.

In the genre of body horror, the body is the aspect that drives the story, it is a deep and visceral exploration of physicality and through this genre the relationship between body, society and control is questioned. Body horror films often explore the disintegration and transformation or any type of extreme physiological change of the human body. In many body horror fictions, the protagonist(s) lose control over their body, or their body goes through some extreme bodily reconfiguration. As Hurley explains: "narrative told by body horror again and again is of a human subject dismantled and demolished: a human body whose integrity is violated, a human identity whose boundaries are breached from all sides" (205). As a youngling we grew up consuming this type of film vigorously and feeling an intense connection to them, back then, we were unaware to formulate why, but it left us morbidly intrigued. Now we understand that these films confront the alienation and estrangement of one's own body. The genre is, in its essence, an exploration of otherness. This parallels the experiences of those navigating non-binary identities and therefore we argue that body horror can be interpreted as a metaphorical expression of gender non-conforming and trans experiences. In this context, body horror movies provide a rich symbolic language that can be harnessed to interrogate the complexities of gender identity.

The dissonance found in these films is akin to the dissonance felt by individuals whose gender expression defies societal norms. The abject and uncanny transformations portrayed in body horror serve as potent metaphors for the challenges faced by non-binary individuals in a world that still grapples with rigid gender constructs. We feel understood within these narratives because we identify with the disgust one feels towards one's own body, the sheer dysphoria, the loss of the idea of the self, the lack of control over the body and the way it is perceived. As a person, concerned with their body and the restrictions of it, dictated by heteronormativity, we connect to these narratives, as their cinematographic depictions of bodies as foreign objects is something we feel and live on a day-to-day basis. Incentivizing the viewer to contemplate the body, as a foreign object can also benefit a new way of thinking about bodies, what we consider to be 'normal' bodies and how we react to otherness, although it is pushed to an absurd level within body horror, it gives space for these questions and considerations, becoming a way for gender conforming people to empathize more with gender non-conforming experiences and open up conversations about queer struggles.

The Body Horror Without Organs: Deleuze and Horror

The seductiveness of body horror is also the more literal and visual deconstructing and disintegrating of bodies. The depiction of bodies that defy categorization, the messiness of it, the non-conformity of it. It is the utter chaos: the amalgamation of man, animal, machine into new hybrid and grotesque alien entities. It has something utterly alluring. What captures our attention and imagination is the unrestrained chaos, the brazen non-conformity. Although these depictions can be unsettling, even revolting, they liberate the body from societal inscriptions and the compulsion to adhere to pre-existing gender and identity norms. Such bodies are in a state of becoming-imperceptible, illegible entities. In that sense body horror can be perceived as questioning and re-imagining the subject/object binary, which is a concept central to the philosophical work of Deleuze. It can be argued that these mutating monstrosities are a cinematic translation of the conceptual surface of what Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari have termed the "Body-Without-Organs". The BwO, is a theoretical construct that challenges traditional structures and configurations. It is, not necessarily, a literal body, more a figurative body, which is animated by intensity and movement. The BwO is not a rejection of organs, it is a rejection of organisms, which within this context are "the organic organization of the organs" (Deleuze and Guattari 158) it is a rejection of hierarchization, a rejection of forms and functions being imposed onto the body. The BwO is a reorganization of the body, embodying a state of disorganization. This challenges the societal imperative imposed upon bodies, demanding organizational adherence with the directive that one must become a structured organism; "You will be organized, you will be an organism, you will articulate your body – otherwise, you're just depraved" (Deleuze and Guattari 159). In essence, the BwO is a manifold manifestation of nomadism that is almost impossible in its cognitive formulation.

This theoretical concept resonates with the transformative themes explored within body horror, as bodies shift from their predefined forms and merge into unprecedented and unclassifiable shapes. In essence, these bodies are in a state of constant 'becoming', a process of pure intensity and transformation. For us, this transformation creates a sense of connectivity and belonging. Witnessing bodies break free from the constraints of societal norms, particularly those associated with a heteronormative society, unleashes raw emotions of excitement within us. The confusion of boundaries within body horror, as bodies evolve and adopt unconventional forms, challenges what constitutes a "normal" or "attractive" body. This disruption of societal expectations, bodily expressions and beauty standards is a tool for questioning and dismantling normative structures. The relationship between body horror and the BwO is, to us, evident in the way both challenges established classifications and venture into the realm of pure potentiality. The BwO, as a philosophical concept, represents a dynamic surface of transformation and becoming, mirroring the ever-evolving nature of the bodies depicted in body horror as they re-organize both limbs and organs in a process of 'becoming-imperceptible'. The parallels between these depictions and the idea of the BwO illustrate how body horror serves as a powerful medium for questioning and subverting established norms, through a theoretical lens, enabling characters to potentially embrace extreme physical deviation as a liberating practice. In this sense, body horror transcends the realm of mere shock value or the grotesque to become a vehicle for philosophical and societal critique, inviting audiences to reconsider and expand their notions of the human body and its place in a complex, multifaceted world. This field of tension is where body horror, at least for us, becomes a seductive medium.

Cinematic Flesh: Analysis of Body Horror Media Through a Queer Lens

Witin the realm of body horror films that challenge traditional gender and corporeal boundaries, there exists a myriad of examples such as David Cronenberg's 'Crimes of the Future' (2022), a film that dives deeper into questions of human evolution and biotechnology. This film imagines a future where human beings evolve in bizarre ways. Some can digest plastic, while others continually grow and regenerate new organs. The film presents a narrative that explores the fluidity and adaptability of the human form, drawing connections to the concepts of post-humanism and the blurred lines between the organic and the synthetic. Similarly, 'eXistenZ' (1999) by Cronenberg challenges the traditional distinction between physical and virtual reality. In this narrative, the characters access a virtual realm known as cyberspace through a "bio-port" physically attached to their bodies via a faux umbilical cord. This immediate connection between human physiology and technology forces individuals to alter their physical bodies to enter a different reality, effectively collapsing the boundaries between the organic and the synthetic. The film presents themes that resonate with Donna Haraway's concept of the cyborg, highlighting the transformative potential of technology in the human experience. We will dissect two titles more in depth, as they delve more deeply into the exploration of the relationships between gender, the process of becoming a cyborg, and the tenets of post-humanism, These films offer a dissection of these themes, inviting audiences to contemplate the fluidity of gender and the ever-evolving boundaries between humanity and technology.

In the avant-garde Japanese film 'Tetsuo: The Iron Man' (1989), directed by Shinya Tsukamoto, an unsettling transformation unfolds, as the protagonist becomes a nightmarish amalgamation of flesh and metal after a fateful encounter with a mysterious metal fetishist. This transformation sets the stage for a mesmerizing exploration of the relationship between humanity and technology in a rapidly industrializing and technology obsessed urban Japanese society. The film, renowned for its visceral and grotesque portrayal, serves as a poignant social commentary of the dehumanizing effects of industrialization, the fetishization of technology, and the relentless pursuit of speed within this context (Alexander 19). Drawing a parallel to Donna Haraway's pioneering concept of the cyborg, we find striking connections within 'Tetsuo.' The most obvious link is the protagonist's metamorphosis into a cyborg being, embodying the very essence of Haraway's idea of technology seamlessly merging with the human form, thereby challenging conventional notions of a legible unified identity. In both Haraway's theoretical framework and 'Tetsuo,' there is an underlying theme of forming intricate relationships with non-human entities. This shared theme underscores the dissolution of rigid boundaries between human and non-human, echoing the fluidity of the cyborg as described by Haraway. 'Tetsuo' delves deep into this theme by employing violent and visceral imagery, particularly in the context of sexuality. The film constructs an erotic and paradoxical juxtaposition between the soft, vulnerable nature of flesh and the cold, unyielding harshness of metal (Shimoaka 177). This juxtaposition serves as a metaphor for the blurring of lines between the organic and the mechanized, evoking a sense of both attraction and revulsion. While the explicit intent of the film does not encompass gender-related issues, its non-heteronormative undertones are quite prevalent upon a closer examination through a queer lens. The narrative of Tetsuo reveals an imperative for the integration of marginalized identities into mainstream society, concurrently advocating for the rejection of entrenched heteronormative patriarchal norms. The film disrupts conventional notions of heteronormative Japanese identity by portraying women as femme fatales and queering masculinity through explicit sexual encounters. One example of this occurs in a scene where the protagonist undergoes emasculation by his girlfriend, who, within a dream sequence, symbolizes male anxieties of inadequacy through a theatrical penetration with her articulated cyborg phallus. This peculiar subjugation of the male protagonist by his monster girlfriend serves as a bizarre questioning of the legitimacy of heteronormative culture. As the film progresses toward its climax, another noteworthy example of queer performances challenging heteronormative power emerges. The metal fetishist is depicted isolated amidst scrap iron, applying makeup—an action that, through a queer reading, can be construed

as preparation for a final seduction. Referencing Haraway's assertion that "cyborg replication is uncoupled from organic reproduction," (3) the film portrays the disenfranchised as compelled to entice the dominant group for survival. This sexualized performance refrains from a destructive motive and, instead, conveys the fetishist's pursuit of acceptance from the protagonist, who personifies a society that marginalizes deviance. By dismantling everything valued by the protagonist, the fetishist attempts to liberate him from the assigned role as an unwitting exploitative figure in pursuit of heteronormative stability.

A film that is more overt in its queer representation of the cyborg, is the French film 'Titane' (2021), directed by Julia Ducournau. It offers a narrative that delves into various themes, one of the most prominent being the exploration of trans identity. The story follows the protagonist, Alexia, who undergoes a transformative journey both physically and in terms of identity. This transformation is set in motion with a childhood car accident that necessitates the implantation of a metal plate in their head. The accident also catalyses a distinctive and unusual sexual fascination with cars and metal, ultimately leading to Alexia's having sex with a being impregnated by a car. As the narrative unfolds, Alexia embarks on a killing spree, compelling her to go on the run and adopt a new identity as Adrian, a long lost boy. This identity transformation involves physical changes like chest and belly binding as well as breaking their own nose. As Adrian, Alexia takes refuge with the lost boy's father, Vincent, who is willing to accept them as their son. However, this willingness becomes compromised once signs of Adrian's pregnancy become increasingly apparent. The closing act of the film sees Alexia giving birth as Adrian, to a hybrid car baby with metal infused into its flesh. As Alexia succumbs and dies during childbirth, we see Vincent affectionately holding the baby, vowing to take care of them. There is a rich range of themes within the narrative of 'Titane' to be unpacked: themes desire, themes of trans identity, themes related to the idea of the cyborg, themes of chosen family and family dynamics. The adoption of Alexia's transformation into Adrian is a potent exploration of the openness and fluidity of gender, The film's overt representation of chest binding serves to highlight the daily challenges and experiences of some trans individuals who go through similar processes to affirm their identities. It underscores the physical and emotional aspects of navigating gender transitions. What becomes important to point out is that throughout this transition, what remains unwavering is Alexia's core identity. Then the narrative challenges preconceived notions about gender by having Alexia, as Adrian, undergo pregnancy and labor, subverting the traditional association of these experiences with being female. It offers a painful but moving commentary on how one's gender identity is not defined by the type of body one inhabits. In doing so, 'Titane' compels viewers to re-evaluate their understanding of gender and the complex interplay between identity and physiology. The search for belonging within chosen families is a theme that resonates deeply with queer communities, where individuals may face rejection from their biological families due to factors related to their bodies, identities, or sexualities. 'Titane' poignantly captures this longing for acceptance and the formation of non-biological bonds, emphasizing the significance of chosen family dynamics. This theme, although not explicitly about gender, intersects with broader discussions of acceptance, identity, and community, which are fundamental in the experiences of many LGBTQ+ individuals. The exploration of the cyborg theme in 'Titane' takes various forms, serving as a central thread woven throughout the narrative.
The most explicit manifestation is the opening car crash, which results in the metal plate implanted in Alexia's head, marking the initial merger of human and machine. A more subtle and nuanced exploration lies in Alexia's burgeoning desire for cars and metal, a desire that blurs the lines between human and machine. This transformation manifests through the pregnancy and its associated bodily changes, for example in this scene depicting the secretion of motor oil from Alexia's reproductive organ. This theme reaches its zenith with the birth of the hybrid human-car baby, a representation of a being that defies categorization as purely human or machine: a cyborg, which is: "a body without organs, that is to say, a body integrated with technology, [which] also includes the genderless nature of technology." (Babal 75). This genderless nature of technology, further underscores the intricate interplay between gender, humanity and technology within 'Titane'.

Haraway's Cyborg as Monstrous Entity

In this sense, these two films delve deep into the essence of the cyborg body as proposed by Donna Haraway, a concept that advocates for the dissolution of fixed boundaries between gender, human and machine, offering an audacious and thought-provoking cinematic exploration of the ever-evolving relationship between humans and technology. While Haraway's formulation of the cyborg remains more of a (geo)political framework, the implications of her ideas find vivid embodiment in body horror films and other horror and science fiction narratives. These narratives offer literal and visceral representations of the destabilisation of heteropatriarchal notions of the self, particularly in the context of Western culture. In these body horror titles, the amalgamation of man, animal, and machine is often presented in a far more vile and unpleasant manner than the harmonious co-existence that Haraway envisions. The kinship between these elements, a recurring theme in Haraway's work, takes on a violent and forced dimension in these visual and narrative explorations. It is a portrayal where the boundaries between human, animal, and machine are blurred, twisted, and torn apart, reflecting a more confrontational and perhaps nightmarish vision of our entanglement with technology and biology, but "Cyborg unities are monstrous and illegitimate" (Haraway, 8). Cyborg writing is in its essence, a way to recode and subvert, a way to survive, it speaks of illegitimate productions, bastards, one and all, spliced chimeric entities, it is chaos, it is noise, it is fractured parts refusing to become a singular whole. It is a rejection of purity and this is perfectly embodied within body horror cinematography. However absurd it may be, these grotesque expressions help us to think about bodies, their

boundaries and their role in society in a more anarchic way, so without a clear hierarchy or order, which opens up avenues of experimental uncertainties, disjointed expressions and undefinable gaps.

"We will cruise as wild, amorous, monstrous malfunctions".
— Legacy Russell, Glitch Feminism

"I know always that I am an outsider; a stranger in this century and among those who are still men."
—H.P. Lovecraft, The Outsider

"We are fashioned creatures, but half made up."
—Mary Shelley, Frankenstein

Chapter 2: Gender-queer Monstrosity: Being or Becoming

{To be...so many...to curl up and unfold, to fill the space, to dance across the surface, to spill over in multitudes. Every time we pick up our pieces, be they crushed or be they torn, we sew them back together, we hide the stitch marks, we hide the scars, we decorate them with tattoos. We make something out of it, because we have to...what else is there to do? We survive, we must. It is not all doom and gloom though; at times we find moments where it does not seem so important or overwhelming or all-consuming to be a gendered body. We like those moments, a pause in pressure, a breath of fresh air. A tiny moment where we might make sense in this current rendition of the world. We always get snapped back to 'reality' though, confronted again and again with being seen as a gendered body, ugh, which puts us again in this position of 'outsider'. We feel like a body snatcher, like we infiltrate heteronormativity with our body, pretending to be one of them cis boys. But their existence is not mine, no, our existence is tormented by a yearning for genderless existence, we still yearn for illegibility and abstraction, we always yearn...will we have to yearn forever? Or maybe will we collectively find more moments to breathe, together?}

In our previous chapter, we flirted with the idea that the medium of body horror harbors untapped potential in questioning the relations between the self, the other and the body. Through its utilization of grotesque absurdity and extreme transmutation, body horror consistently lays bare what are the limitations of bodies and breaks away from the traditional delineations of the human form, inviting audiences to reconsider their understanding of the human body and its place in our contemporary society. The narrative landscape is populated by characters undergoing metamorphoses that cause their bodies to transform. In this process of transformation there is a re-imagining of humans as spliced creatures and abstract beings, illegible spawns, unnatural and monstrous entities. The reading of monsters, as queer, because of their non-normative nature, is not an entirely novel conceptualization, but it will form the crux of our inquiry in this chapter. We shall investigate the intricate intersections and intertwined contexts between queerness and monstrosity. The first part of this chapter will function as an analysis of the queerness that is present within the genre of horror as to actually solidify our queer reading of horror, then we will highlight the way horror has been used to vilify gender-queer bodies, to come at a point of reclamation of horror within the framework of queerness. The second part of this chapter will focus on the idea that one of the functions of a monster, can be the one of the messenger,

The queer body as monstrous body

Throughout the manifesto of 'Glitch Feminism' Russell argues for a clear stance on the relation between body and queer identity: we must view the queer body as a glitch, the glitch poses a vehicle of refusal and nonperformance. The glitch is of course an error, something that halts a system, making it either unpredictable or unable to function, an unwanted side effect. Can monsters not be viewed in similar fashion? Are they not unwanted, unhinged? Do the 'normal' characters not shriek in terror when they encounter a monstrosity that is beyond their comprehension? Some being that is deemed wrong: a horrible experiment, a gross mutation, a xenomorphic alien, an abomination. A creature that is out of place, perpetually in defiance of something, be it God or be it nature. The monster is a glitch in its own right. A refusal towards normativity: "A monster may also be that which eludes gender definition" (Brooks 219). In the thesis ' Some-ness in No-When: Queer Temporalities in the Horror Genre' by Melody Hope Cooper, they come with a compelling argument, asserting that, specifically within the context of horror: "Queer is not necessarily a specific sexuality or person; it is an umbrella term for anything non-normative" (2). Within depictions of horror media, monsters are the non-normative character counterparts to the normative human characters, in a narrative structure that often pits humans against other, or human against human, through the fear of otherness. When looking at these non-normative characters, we can then apply the following two arguments proposed by Cooper: "The characters who are shown as non-normative often do not fit into heteronormative society and therefore can be labelled queer" (2), and "The bodies of the characters are often non-normative and therefore deemed monstrous" (2). Cooper creates this triangle, between non-normative, monstrous and queer, that creates a framework which they later elaborate on: "The creation of the monster ties back into the previous definition given to the queer body, which is any body not conforming to social norms, described as monstrous or grotesque. The queer body is deemed to be these things because it poses a threat to heteronormative society. The queer body does not conform to the prescribed "truths" of heterosexuality and instead demands to be accepted as it exists". (3–4) Aligning with Cooper's perspective,

Ana Cristina Santos echoes a parallel sentiment, contending that: “cis-heteronormativity fosters the conditions under which certain identities, practices and experiences are bound to remain monstrous,” (78). Being gender-queer forms a threat, because the queer body defies categorization, it defies a concrete, singular, stable definition, it challenges the cultural imagination of gender as fixed and natural, that which has been prevalent for most of human history, which makes being gender-queer highly disruptive. Anything that is too disruptive or too different is cause for fear and anxiety, because it taps into a larger fear of the unknown, which according to study could be fundamental: “fear of the unknown may be a, or possibly the, fundamental fear” (Carleton 39). To put it in more simple terms: “The strangeness attached to the non-binary body and experience is enough to yield the label of monster.” (Santos 79)

The conceptualization of queer bodies, particularly those embodying gender non-conformity and trans identities, as monstrous entities is not a novel proposition. This proposition is rooted in historically negative, discriminatory, and derogatory connotations associated with the term “monster”. This is one way the gender-queer as monster can exist, a way of vilification and othering. In 1978, radical feminist philosopher, theologian and author Mary Daly, who is well respected and celebrated within pockets of the Trans Exclusionary Radical Feminist movement, or TERF circles, released her work ‘Gyn/Ecology: The Metaethics of Radical Feminism’, in which she strategically employs an appropriation of Mary Shelley’s description of Frankenstein’s Monster as an allegorical representation for transgender women. In the eyes of Daly, the transgender, and specifically the post-op transgender woman, is artificially created, through scientific and technological manipulations of the body. Daly sees them as substitutes for ‘real’ woman which leads her to make this accusation against trans women that they would be involved in a “necrophillic invasion” of the female world (Daly, 50). Although Daly may not be the progenitor of such comparisons, her explicit parallel between transgender identity and a literary monster constitutes a noteworthy example of the pervasive notion of ‘transgender as monster.’ This conceptualization functions as a means to vilify gender non-conformity, fostering a violent perception of transness through the use of terms such as “necrophilic” and “invasion”. Daly’s insinuation posits that spaces designated for women, considered safe or pure, are now perceived as compromised by what she deems as an aberration. This deliberate association between transgender identity and the monstrous serves as an illustration of how such metaphors are weaponized to stigmatize and marginalize those who deviate from established gender norms, perpetuating harmful narratives that resonate within societal discourse.

However, we can flip the script by thinking of other, more positive ways the gender-queer as monster can exist, as Santos exclaims: ‘Once it becomes possible to overcome the terror triggered by the misfit body of the monster, a whole range of possibility and freedom emerges. ‘ (Santos, 91). For instance in ‘My Words to Victor Frankenstein Above the Village of Chamounix: Performing Transgender Rage’ (1994) Stryker also links herself to the Frankenstein monster, partly in reaction to TERF’s like Daly, but also because, Stryker, argues that the transsexual body is unnatural, a technological construction as a desperate attempt by medical science to engineer bodies as normative as possible by cutting, sewing and stitching bodies into familiar shapes according to the normative vision of a heteropatriarchal society (237). However, instead of vilification, Stryker embraces the monster, by differentiating herself from those who take offense at being labelled a ‘creature’, arguing that such resistance stems from the perceived threat posed by these terminologies to the elevated status that places individuals above mere material existence, as well as the loss of superior person-hood that the term ‘creature’ suggests. Stryker exhibits a lack of shame, when it comes to this proposed loss, as she acknowledges her egalitarian relationship with non-human material Being (240). In acknowledging this, Stryker resists models of violence and oppression meant to weaponize or solidify identity categorization, redirecting the force of the offense and transforming it from something that is meant to instil anger, shame, self-loathing and guilt into resilience and pride.

Stryker’s monster is, in that sense, akin to Haraway’s cyborg, as the monster assumes a role within ontology, paralleling the assertion that the cyborg functions as our ontology, shaping our basic understanding of being and politics (Haraway, 104). Both concepts are forms of affinity-based politics, political frameworks that centres around shared affinities, connections and relationships amongst individuals or groups, instead of relying on essentialism. Affinity-based politics are designed to foster relationality, connection and understanding. Haraway speaks of “a creature of social reality as well as a creature of fiction.” (104) and within the Cyborg Manifesto it is clear that, for Haraway, the distinction between social reality and fiction is not that clear-cut. Both concepts, are also forms of assemblages: Haraway’s constructed cyborg and Stryker’s sewn together monster. Assemblages remove binaries as it de-privileges bodies as human (Puar 4) which is echoed in Haraway’s remark: “Why should our bodies end at the skin, or include at best other beings encapsulated by skin? ” (Haraway 114). An assemblage is not without friction, as the monsters body is forcefully sewn together, there are things there that might not connect smoothly, might not fit one hundred percent, a multi-faceted, multi-layered entity, where the some of its parts, is greater than the whole. If we view the monster, through the lens of the assemblage, through the lens of affinity-politics, the term monster, like the term cyborg, surpasses its mere fictional role and becomes an empowering identity within our lived and embodied realities.

Becoming Monster: a messy tear from normativity – a queer messenger

Delving into the realm of monstrosity requires an exploration of its multifaceted dimensions when contemplating role of gender-queer monstrosities. Throughout history, from the ancient civilizations to the captivating bestiaries

and folklore of the medieval era, the concept of monstrosity has been a perennial subject of inquiry. The Renaissance period witnessed a renewed fascination with monsters, exemplified by literary pieces such as John Milton's magnum opus, "Paradise Lost," and Dante Alighieri's infernal epic, "Inferno." The 18th and 19th centuries ushered in a Gothic tradition that perpetuated the allure of monstrosities, epitomized by Mary Shelley's iconic creation in "Frankenstein." These monsters, embedded in a lineage of cultural narratives, have functioned not merely as vessels of horror but as various sorts of messengers. Looking at the etymology of the word monster, we find that it is derived from the Latin monstrum, which in itself Is derived from the verb moneo, which means "to remind, warn, instruct or foretell" (Riddle 399). In the chapter 'The Origins of Monsters' from the book 'The Monster In The Machine' by Zakiya Hanafi, they explain that monsters were by definition a terrible prodigy, not for what it was, but for what it symbolized: a messenger from the other world. In their form monsters opposed human definition by eroding clear distinctions between man, beast, devil and god eluding to transgressions and a break down of social order (Hanafi 18). Monsters carry a meaning that transcend the realm of mundane terror or mere shock. The symbolic language woven into the fabric of monstrous beings has consistently served as harbingers of imminent upheavals or extraordinary events (political shifts, calamitous wars, botched or fruitful harvests, natural disasters) fostering an intricate dynamic between cultural, societal, and individual perspectives. The historical trajectory of monsters as messengers unveils an interplay, showcasing their versatility beyond mere agents of horror. Their enduring presence in the cultural lexicon underlines their capacity to communicate, akin to omens or signs, deciphering the capricious turns of fate. In diverse indigenous and non-western cultures globally, mythologies feature monstrous beings as bearers of cultural wisdom regarding for example: fertility, balance, harvest, animal well-being. In this context they serve as messengers imparting vital insights about the natural world, spiritual realms, and the delicate equilibrium between humankind and the environment. These narratives, often intertwining the monstrous with the sacred, make them closer to deities, which challenges Western preconceptions that exclusively perceive monsters through the prism of fear and malevolence. Across various cultures, diverse mythological creatures such as the Qilin in Chinese mythology, the Kapre in Philippine mythology, the Bunyip and Yowie in Aboriginal Australian mythology, the Chaneques in Aztec mythology, and the Kokopelli in Native American mythology exemplify the multifaceted roles monsters assume in conveying cultural insights. Monsters, in their capacity as messengers, compel humanity to confront the unknown, question societal norms, and engage in an exploration of the complexities intrinsic to the human experience.

In contemporary literature and cinema, the archetype of the monster as messenger persists. Modern narratives frequently harness the power of monstrous figures to convey socio-political commentaries, reflections on identity, and critiques of prevailing power structures. This is exemplified in titles such as 'District 9' [2009] where the monsters, or aliens in the case of the film, serve as an allegory for apartheid, or the 'Godzilla' franchise where the monster symbolizes the consequences of nuclear power and acts as a stark warning about the misuse of technology. But also within the genre of body horror, there are monsters as messengers. In our previous chapter we explored films such as 'Titane' and 'Tetsuo', these can also be analyzed through the perspective of monster as messenger. Through our queer reading of 'Tetsuo' the becoming-monster of the protagonist can be seen as symbolic representation of the fluidity of gender and sexual identity. The merging of the human body with machinery as a new and frictional assemblage, may be seen as a metaphor for the intersectionality and multiplicity of queer identities, where sexuality and desire intersect with societal fears and prejudices. We also read the transformation of the protagonist as a way to be liberated from the exploitative heteronormative stability they were exploited by. In 'Titane' the hybrid cyborg-baby that is born at the end of the film can be seen as a messenger of change: Its presence symbolizes the unconventional and non-normative, a defiance of traditional gender categorizations and a rejection of predetermined roles, as it is a bastard child of man and machine. This aligns with the monster as a messenger archetype, conveying a message about the limitations and artificial constructs of sex and gender norms. The father figure, Victor, also accepts the baby, and vows to take care of it, even though the baby is a monstrous entity and not even related by blood. In this sense the baby can be viewed as a messenger of new beginnings.

In the contemporary context, the gender-queer as monster can emerge as a compelling extension of the historical role of monsters as messengers. The gender-queer figure, existing beyond the confines of normative gender constructs, can be viewed as heralding significant societal shifts towards a different way of perceiving bodies and identities. Indulging in a zeitgeist that moves away from essentialism and moves towards abstract, frictional assemblages of multiplicities, a zeitgeist that acknowledges: "no construction is a whole" (Haraway 109). The gender-queer figure, much like the monsters of ancient Greek, Norse and Japanese mythologies or the sewn together monstrosities of Gothic literature, carries the weight of cultural significance as 'outsiders' interacting with society, often in frictional ways. The gender-queer signals a departure from binary frameworks and heteronormative "truths", and exemplify the frictions that spawn from this departure. Stacy Holman Jones & Anne Harris write: "queer is in constant conversation with the monstrous fringe of town" in their text 'Monsters, desire and the creative queer body'. What they elude to is the idea that sometimes queer roles and identities act in socially acceptable manners, while other times the way of gender identity, bodily expression and expressions of love go unseen because they fall outside of the heteronormative "truth". When they are seen, they often are misunderstood, inciting fear and resistance as it is an illegal expression, causing the gender-queer to be shunned, much like Frankenstein's monster (Jones, Harris 519). The gender-queer as monster resounds as a call for embracing complex multitudes, fostering inclusivity, and redefining the narrative surrounding gender in ways that rupture from the historical limitations of

cultural imaginations. The gender-queer monster acts as a harbinger of a transformative paradigm, as Preciado states: “The monster is one who lives in transition. One whose face, body and behaviors cannot yet be considered true in a predetermined regime of knowledge and power” (Preciado 23–24). The very act of living in transition, of saying no to gender, of using they/them pronouns, of refusing to perform gender as expected, becomes an act of resistance against the hegemonic forces that seek to control and define the parameters of gender identity.

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